Account Services and DMCA Kit

Part 1 is a menu of account services you could offer: closing, recovering, backing up and tracking down accounts. Part 2 is everything you need to send a DMCA takedown notice, with templates. This is practical guidance, not legal advice. For anything with real money or legal risk at stake, talk to a lawyer. Links, form names and platform policies change, so check each one before you rely on it.

Part 1: Account Services Menu

The rules that protect you and your clients

1. **Never ask for, store or receive passwords.** The client logs in on their own device. You guide them by video call or screen share, and they type their own credentials. If you hold passwords, you become the target and the liability.
2. **Written authorization first.** Every service happens with the client's explicit, written permission for the specific accounts (the authorization text below).
3. **Only their own accounts.** Not a partner's, parent's or employer's, unless that person has authorized it in writing. Accounts of someone who has died are a different, legal process (executor or next of kin) and out of scope.
4. **Never impersonate the client** to a company's support team. Companies usually require the account holder, and impersonation can breach their terms or the law. You can coach; the client does the talking.
5. **No guarantees on recovery.** Providers decide, using their own verification rules. Tell clients in advance that some accounts can't be recovered.
6. **Back up before you delete.** Closing is permanent. Anything marked "has data worth saving" is exported first and checked.
7. **Beware recovery scams.** "Hackers who recover accounts" are almost always fraud. Tell clients you only use official recovery channels, so they can spot imitations.

Service 1: Account inventory and health check

What it is: a complete map of the person's accounts, using the Account Inventory Worksheet.

Steps:

1. Give the client the worksheet and the Memory Jogger tab. Ask them to list what they remember.
2. Hunt for forgotten accounts together (see Service 5).
3. Fill the status, 2FA and recovery columns. The Summary tab shows weak spots.
4. Agree an action for each account: keep, review, close, recover, back up or find.
5. Fix the top risks first: email, Apple or Google account, banking, phone carrier, password manager.

Deliverable: the completed worksheet (stored by the client, not you) and a one-page priority list.

Service 2: Closing old accounts

Before closing, check each account:

- **Data:** does it hold photos, messages, documents or purchase records they'd want? Export first (Service 4).
- **Subscriptions and balances:** cancel recurring payments, use or withdraw balances and rewards, and download receipts.
- **Dependencies:** is the account used to log in elsewhere ("Sign in with Google", "Sign in with Apple", "Continue with Facebook")? Move those logins to a regular email and password first.
- **Email accounts:** closing an email address can lock the person out of every service that sends it a reset link. Close email last, and only when nothing depends on it.
- **Shared accounts:** family plans, joint accounts and business pages need others' agreement.

Steps for each account:

1. Log in (the client does this).
2. Find account deletion in settings (search the help center for "delete account", not "deactivate", which usually only hides it).
3. Understand the grace period. Many services keep a deleted account for around 30 days before removing it permanently. Note the date.
4. Confirm deletion by email, and keep the confirmation.
5. Update the worksheet: status closed, date and notes.

Limits: some services make deletion hard or impossible (data retained for legal reasons, or deletion only by email request). Say so at the start. For data held by data brokers, a separate opt-out process applies.

Service 3: Recovering accounts

Principles: use only the provider's official recovery flow, from a device and location the account has seen before if possible, and expect waiting periods.

Steps:

1. Identify exactly what is wrong: forgotten password, lost two-factor device, hacked, disabled for a policy reason, or an old address they can't reach.
2. Gather what the provider may ask for: old passwords, the recovery email or phone, the date the account was created, recent payment details, the device the person usually signed in on.
3. Start recovery from a familiar device and network (home Wi-Fi, the usual phone).
4. Follow the provider's recovery page (Google, Apple, Microsoft, Meta and others each have their own). Answer exactly, and don't guess repeatedly, which can lengthen lockouts.
5. If a recovery email or phone is gone, use the provider's "I don't have access" option and prepare for a delay.
6. Once in: change the password, set up a second factor, add recovery options, save recovery codes, and log out of unknown sessions.
7. Record what worked in the worksheet.

If the account was hacked: change the password and second factor first, check forwarding rules and connected apps, and check other accounts that used the same password or email.

Honest limits: if all recovery paths fail, the account may be gone. Plan the next step: open a new account, tell contacts, and recover what's possible from backups.

Service 4: Backing up account contents

This is the App Data Backup Menu: pick the method per service (data download request, rclone, IMAP, CalDAV, app export). Store results in the household's exports folder and run a restore check. Close the account only after the export has been opened and confirmed.

Service 5: Tracking down lost or abandoned accounts

Where to look:

- **Email archives:** search the main inboxes for "welcome", "verify your email", "confirm your account", "receipt", "your order", "password reset" and "subscription". Sort by sender to see a list of services.
- **Password stores:** the browser's saved logins (Chrome, Safari, Firefox), iCloud Keychain, any old password manager.
- **Connected apps:** Google account › Security › Third-party apps and services; Apple account › Sign in with Apple; Facebook › Apps and websites. These list the services the account has been used to log into.
- **Breach lookups:** haveibeenpwned.com shows which breached services an email address appears in, which is a good list of forgotten accounts.
- **Financial trails:** old bank and card statements for subscriptions, and annualcreditreport.com for old credit and loan accounts.
- **Forgotten money:** state unclaimed-property sites and missingmoney.com for dormant accounts, balances and refunds.
- **Devices:** old phones, tablets and computers may still be signed in to accounts. Check them before wiping.
- **Domain and website history:** old personal sites, blogs, domain registrations and hosting.

Then add each find to the worksheet and decide an action.

Service 6 (optional add-on): Hardening

Password manager, two-factor on the important accounts, passkeys, recovery contacts and recovery codes. Tie this to the break glass sheet.

Authorization text (client signs)

I, [Client Name], authorize [Your Name] to help me with the following accounts: [list or "those marked on my account inventory worksheet"]. This help is limited to [reviewing, closing, recovering, backing up] these accounts. I understand that I will log in to my own accounts and that [Your Name] will not ask for or store my passwords. I understand that recovery is not guaranteed, that closing an account can be permanent, and that I should confirm any data I want to keep has been saved before an account is closed. I can withdraw this authorization at any time.

Signed: _____ Date: _____

Scope, pricing and risk notes

- **Scope creep:** agree the list of accounts and actions up front. Add accounts only by written message.
- **If it's a favor:** say so, but still use the authorization. It protects both of you.
- **If you charge:** consider a flat price per account or per session, not per success. Don't promise recovery. Check whether your area requires a business license or insurance.
- **Time:** closings and recoveries involve waiting periods (days or weeks). Set a follow-up date in your tracker.
- **Records:** keep a log of what you did, when and with whose permission, but never a record of passwords.
- **Mistakes:** the most common are closing an email account too early and deleting before exporting. Use the checklists.

Part 2: DMCA Takedown Kit

What a DMCA notice is and isn't

The Digital Millennium Copyright Act (US) has a notice-and-takedown process (17 U.S.C. §512). If your copyrighted work is posted somewhere without permission, you can send a notice to the **service provider** (the platform or host). If it follows the rules, the provider is expected to remove the material promptly to keep its legal protection.

It applies when:

- You (or the person you act for) **own the copyright**, for example photos you took, writing you wrote, video you filmed.
- The material is posted on a service, and someone other than the owner put it there without permission.

It does not apply when:

- You are *in* a photo but didn't take it. The photographer usually owns the copyright, not the subject.
- You want to remove criticism, a bad review or a news story. A DMCA notice used for that can be abuse.

- The use may be fair use (commentary, criticism, parody, news reporting, education). You are expected to consider this before sending.
- You want an account closed or recovered. That is a different process (Part 1).

For harassment, impersonation, private information or intimate images, use the platform's own reporting tools (see "Other routes" below).

Who can file

The **copyright owner**, or someone **authorized in writing** to act for them. If you file for a family member or client, get a signed authorization first (template below).

Before you file: checklist

- [ ] I know who owns the copyright (and can show it: original files with metadata, drafts, raw photos, the date taken).
- [ ] I have not given permission, and I'm not aware of anyone who has (a license, a contract, a share setting).
- [ ] I considered whether the use could be fair use.
- [ ] I have the exact URL of each infringing page or file (not just the site's homepage).
- [ ] I have saved evidence: screenshots with the date and URL visible, the page saved as PDF, and the original file.
- [ ] I know the right place to send it (below).
- [ ] I've decided what contact details to provide. **The notice may be shared with the person who posted the material,** so consider a business address, P.O. box or dedicated email rather than a home address.
- [ ] I understand the penalties: the notice is signed **under penalty of perjury** as to authority, and knowingly misrepresenting that material is infringing can create liability (§512(f)).

Registration: you don't need to register the work to send a DMCA notice. You do need a US registration before suing for infringement of a US work, and registering before an infringement (or within three months of publication) affects the damages you can claim. If you may want to go further, talk to a lawyer about registering first.

Step 1: Capture evidence

1. Save a screenshot showing the URL, the date and the material.
2. Save the page (Print to PDF).

3. Keep the original file with its metadata, and any proof of creation date.
4. Record each URL in the log below.
5. If the page might disappear, save it before sending a notice (and consider a web archive).

Step 2: Find the right recipient

1. **Try the platform's own copyright form first.** Most major platforms (Google and YouTube, Meta, X, TikTok, Pinterest, Reddit, WordPress and others) have a dedicated copyright report form, usually found by searching "[platform] copyright report" or "[platform] DMCA". These are usually faster than email.
2. **If there's no form, find the designated agent.** US service providers register a DMCA agent. Search the US Copyright Office's DMCA Designated Agent Directory (dmca.copyright.gov/osp).
3. **For a standalone website:** find who hosts it with a hosting lookup tool or WHOIS, then send the notice to the host's abuse or DMCA contact. If the site uses a CDN like Cloudflare, the CDN may forward your notice to the host.
4. **Search results:** to remove a page from Google Search, use Google's copyright removal request form, in addition to contacting the site.
5. **Outside the US:** a US provider follows the DMCA, but the site's host or country may have different rules. Many platforms accept DMCA-style notices from anywhere. For non-US hosts, look for the host's own copyright policy.

What a valid notice must contain (§512(c)(3))

1. A physical or electronic **signature** of the owner or authorized agent.
2. **Identification of the copyrighted work** (or a representative list, if many).
3. **Identification of the infringing material** and information reasonably sufficient for the provider to find it (the URL).
4. **Your contact information** (name, address, phone number, email).
5. A **statement that you believe in good faith** that the use is not authorized by the owner, its agent or the law.
6. A statement that the information is **accurate**, and **under penalty of perjury**, that you are authorized to act for the owner.

Template A: Takedown notice

Subject: DMCA Takedown Notice: [work title or description]

To: [Designated Agent / Copyright Team], [Platform or Host Name] [Address or email of designated agent]

Date: [date]

I am writing to notify you of copyright infringement on your service and to request that the infringing material be removed.

1. Copyrighted work: I am the copyright owner of [describe the work, e.g. "a photograph titled 'Lake Michigan Sunset' taken by me on June 4, 2024"]. The original is [available at / can be provided on request]: [URL of the original, if any].

2. Infringing material: The following material infringes my copyright. It is located at:

- [URL 1]
- [URL 2]

3. Contact information: [Full name] [Mailing address] [Phone] [Email]

4. Good faith statement: I have a good faith belief that the use of the material described above is not authorized by the copyright owner, its agent, or the law.

5. Accuracy and authority statement: I state that the information in this notification is accurate, and under penalty of perjury, that I am the owner, or authorized to act on behalf of the owner, of an exclusive right that is allegedly infringed.

6. Request: Please remove or disable access to the material identified above promptly and confirm when this has been done.

Signature: /[typed full name]/ Date: [date]

Template B: Written authorization (for filing on someone's behalf)

I, [Owner Name], am the owner of the copyright in the following work(s): [description]. I authorize [Your Name] to act as my agent to send notices under the Digital Millennium Copyright Act concerning these works, and to communicate with the relevant platforms about them. I confirm that I have not authorized the uses described in the notices. I understand that the notices are made under penalty of perjury and that I am responsible for the accuracy of my ownership claims. I may withdraw this authorization in writing at any time.

Signed: _____ Date: _____

Template C: Short version for platform web forms

Most forms ask for the same pieces. Prepare these answers in advance:

- **Your relationship to the work:** I am the copyright owner / authorized agent.
- **Work description:** [short description and where the original can be seen].
- **Infringing URLs:** one per line.
- **Good-faith statement:** tick the box, or paste the statement from Template A.
- **Accuracy and perjury statement:** tick the box, or paste it from Template A.
- **Signature:** your full legal name.

Template D: Follow-up if nothing happens

Subject: Follow-up: DMCA notice [reference number, if any]

I sent a DMCA notice on [date] regarding [URLs]. I haven't received a response and the material is still online. A copy of the original notice is attached. Please confirm the status and remove the infringing material promptly. If I've sent this to the wrong contact, please forward it to your designated agent or tell me where to send it.

[Name, contact details]

Wait about 7 to 10 business days before following up. After that, try the host, the CDN or the search engine, and consider legal advice.

What happens next

1. **The provider removes the material** (usually within days) and notifies the person who posted it.
2. **That person may file a counter-notice.** If so, the provider forwards it to you. Under §512(g), the material may be restored in about 10 to 14 business days **unless you tell the provider you've filed a court action** against the poster.
3. **Repeat infringers:** providers must have a policy to terminate accounts of repeat infringers.
4. **If the material comes back,** send a new notice. Keep your log.

If you receive a counter-notice, stop and get legal advice before deciding whether to sue.

If your own content was removed by mistake (counter-notice)

If a notice was wrongly sent against your content, most platforms offer a counter-notification form. A valid counter-notice includes your signature, identification of the removed material and where it was, a statement **under penalty of perjury** that you believe in good faith it was removed by mistake or misidentification, and your consent to the jurisdiction of the federal court for your address (or, if outside the US, a court where the provider is located), plus acceptance of service from the person who filed the notice. Only file one if you genuinely believe the removal was wrong.

Evidence and tracking log

Date found	Platform	URL	Work infringed	Evidence saved (Y/N)	Notice sent (date, method)	Reference no.	Response	Status

Other routes (when it isn't a copyright problem)

- **Impersonation or fake accounts:** use the platform's impersonation report form.
- **Private information, harassment, or threats:** use the platform's abuse reporting, and contact the police if there's a threat.
- **Intimate images shared without consent:** use the platform's dedicated reporting tool and StopNCII.org, which can help prevent known images spreading. Contact the police where appropriate.
- **Outdated or personal information in search results:** Google's tools for removing personal information and results about you.
- **Photos of you that you didn't take:** ask the person who took them, or the platform's privacy or image-rights reporting where available.
- **Serious or financial harm:** consult a lawyer. A cease-and-desist letter from an attorney can work when forms don't.

Common mistakes

- Sending a notice for something you don't own the copyright to.
- Using a DMCA notice to remove criticism or negative reviews.
- Giving a home address that gets forwarded to the poster.
- Listing a homepage instead of the exact URL of each infringing item.
- Forgetting to save evidence before the content is removed.

- Ignoring a counter-notice. The clock matters.

Good practice for your service

- Offer DMCA help only for works the client owns, with Template B signed.
- Don't act as their legal representative. Say clearly that you are helping with paperwork.
- Keep copies of every notice and response with the client's records.